DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

How Does a Convert Join the Tree of Avraham?

Derech Hashem 2:4:3-5

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 4, paragraphs 3 (from "omnam") to 5, with a first look at paragraph 6 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 24 June 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: why are we affected by Adam?

The class resumes towards the end of paragraph 3, a long paragraph, at the word "omnam." The Rabbi summarised: Adam should not have sinned, and had he not, his children would have been born on his elevated level. He sinned and had children in a lowered state.

People ask why they should be responsible for Adam HaRishon. The Rabbi answered: you are not responsible for what he did, but you live with its reality. It is like a mother who smokes or drinks during pregnancy. You cannot say it is unfair that you are responsible for her actions; you are not. But she lowered her own level of health, and the child is born into that.

Hashem left humanity the potential to return and set a limited time for it, about two thousand years, the time of the roots. Anyone who raised himself back to the level of Adam before the sin would, so to speak, "edit the genes" of all his descendants, who would grow as branches from that root. When the period ended Hashem examined everyone. There were righteous people like Metushelah, but the only one who had risen to that level was Avraham.

The end of paragraph 3: seventy nations and one tree

The Ramhal states that it was determined that no one else had reached the level of Adam before the sin, so they remain on his level after the sin. Avraham alone was chosen, elevated through his deeds and established as a precious, elevated tree that would bring forth branches to match.

At this point Hashem divided the rest of humanity into seventy nations. There are different levels among them, the Ramhal says clearly, but all remain at the level of Adam after the sin. Only Yisrael, the descendants of Avraham, are in the elevated state. With that, the time of the roots closed and the time of the branches began, the age we are still in. From then on, a person born is a branch, strongly shaped by the tree he stems from, and "it's no longer in your control."

A participant asked whether Moshe Rabbenu did not also reach the level of a root. The Rabbi said no: the time was over. "It's not about how holy or not you are. It's the reality." There had to

be a period for setting down the roots of humanity, and Hashem set it at the first third of the six thousand years.

Another participant raised an excellent question: Avraham had several branches, Yishmael, the children he sent to the east, and Yishak. If Muslims come from Yishmael, should they not share the same status? The Rabbi called it a brilliant question and said they would see.

Paragraph 4: conversion as grafting

The next paragraph explains the mechanics of something we already know. If you are a branch of a tree on a far lower level, what happens when you become Jewish? You are grafted onto the tree of Avraham.

The Ramhal says that Hashem in His great kindness, even after closing the time of the roots, gave a place to the branches of the other nations. Logically, every descendant should have had to stay with his root. But by their own free choice they can uproot themselves from their tree and enter another, becoming a leaf on the tree of Avraham. That is what it means that Avraham is the father of converts, and that "all the families of the earth shall be blessed through you": everyone, however far, has the ability to connect to him. If a person does not make the effort, he stays under his own root.

What if a whole nation converted? The Rabbi noted, with reference to the Kuzari, that since the time of roots is over, a nation cannot convert as a root. Each individual leaf would have to join the tree of Avraham separately, and the nation would lose its status as a nation, becoming fully absorbed into the tree.

He was critical of the popular claim that converts are really Jewish souls; according to this approach it does not fit. He acknowledged that there are later sources, such as something along these lines in the Or HaHayim, and allowed that sometimes a convert may truly descend from Avraham's branch and simply have lost his way over the generations.

Paragraph 5: the 600,000 main branches

Just as humanity as a whole is divided into a time of roots and a time of branches, each tree also has its main branches. The Rabbi asked the group to guess, before reading further, what the main branches of Avraham are, and where we find a fixed number for the Jewish people.

The answer: 600,000, the number who left Egypt, from whom the Jewish nation was formed. Everyone born after them is considered part of one of those 600,000 main branches. At that point the tree reached maturity; all its main branches were developed, and we are all leaves on them. This is the meaning of the saying that there are 600,000 letters in the Torah (not precisely, the Rabbi noted, but as a concept). A participant pointed out that the total who left was about two million including women and children, and the Rabbi agreed, adding with a smile that the families are included with each branch.

As for the earlier question, the Rabbi said that whatever the answer, the children of Yishmael or of Avraham's other sons are certainly not among the main branches; those are only the ones who left Egypt. We do not know how many main branches the other nations have, but the same concept applies there too.

A first look at paragraph 6: one more chance at Sinai

The Ramhal adds that Hashem did a great kindness with all the nations. He gave them one more chance, until the giving of the Torah. Had they accepted it, they could have been taken back, somehow, to the age of roots, and started afresh. The Rabbi admitted the Ramhal does not explain the mechanics, but suggested it was a complete refresh. This, he said, is the meaning of the Gemara that at Matan Torah the zuhama (the impurity from the serpent) ceased: it was a total cleansing, "a restart button." The Midrash mentions only three nations being offered the Torah, but the Ramhal clearly implies that all seventy had the chance. Because they declined, it is now sealed, and the only way in is as an individual branch, through conversion.

A participant asked about Esav, who was a branch of Avraham's tree. The Rabbi called it a good question that he would need to think about. On the seventy nations, he noted that we no longer know who is who, but the concept remains: we still offer the seventy bulls on Sukkot. As a child he thought there were only seventy countries and was shocked to learn there are around 194.

Summary

- We are not responsible for Adam's sin, but like a child affected by a mother's habits in pregnancy, we are born into its consequences.
- After the time of roots, humanity was divided into seventy nations on the lower level, with Avraham's descendants alone on the elevated level.
- Paragraph 4: an individual from any nation can graft himself onto Avraham's tree through conversion; a nation cannot convert as a root.
- Paragraph 5: the 600,000 who left Egypt are the main branches, and every Jew is a leaf on one of them.
- The nations had one more chance at Matan Torah; having declined it, only individual conversion remains.

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